Four Canons

on

The Water is Wide

for Flutes
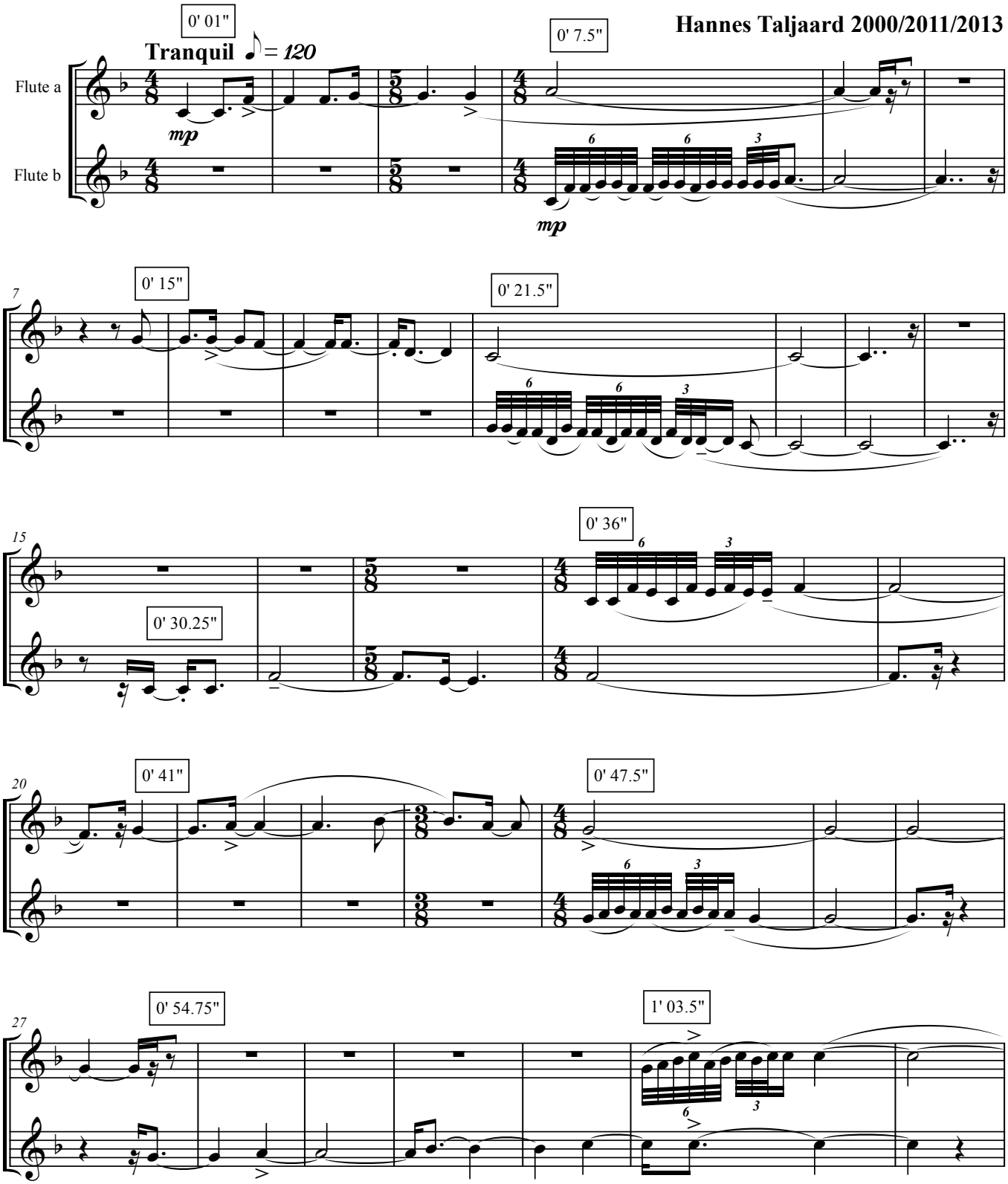
Canon 1: Streams

Hannes Taljaard

2000/2011/2013

Canon 1

Streams
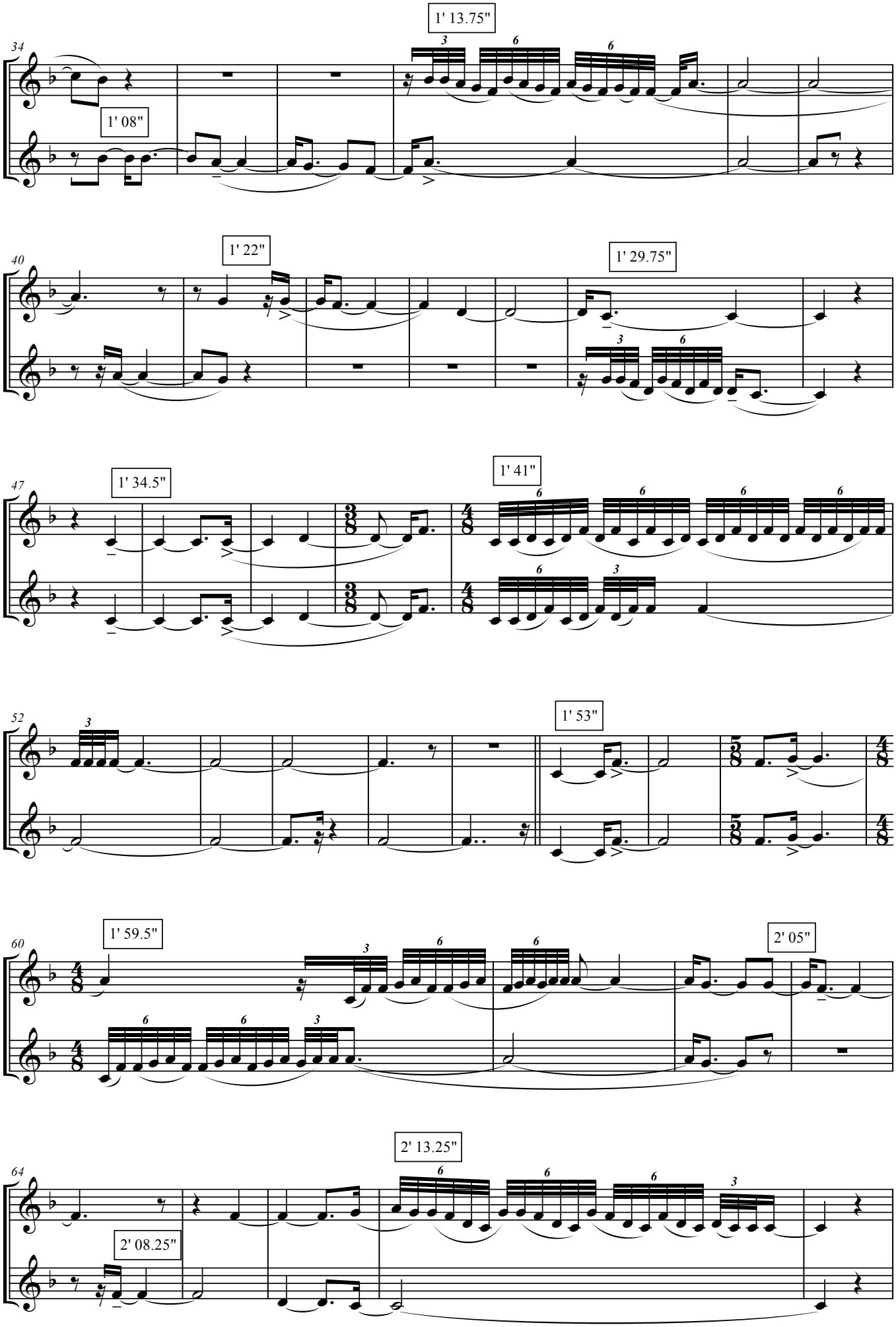


Play the thirty second notes as short as possible. Their durations can be slightly unequal, and each group of ornaments should preferably be heard as an accelerando. Other rhythms must be played precisely as notated.
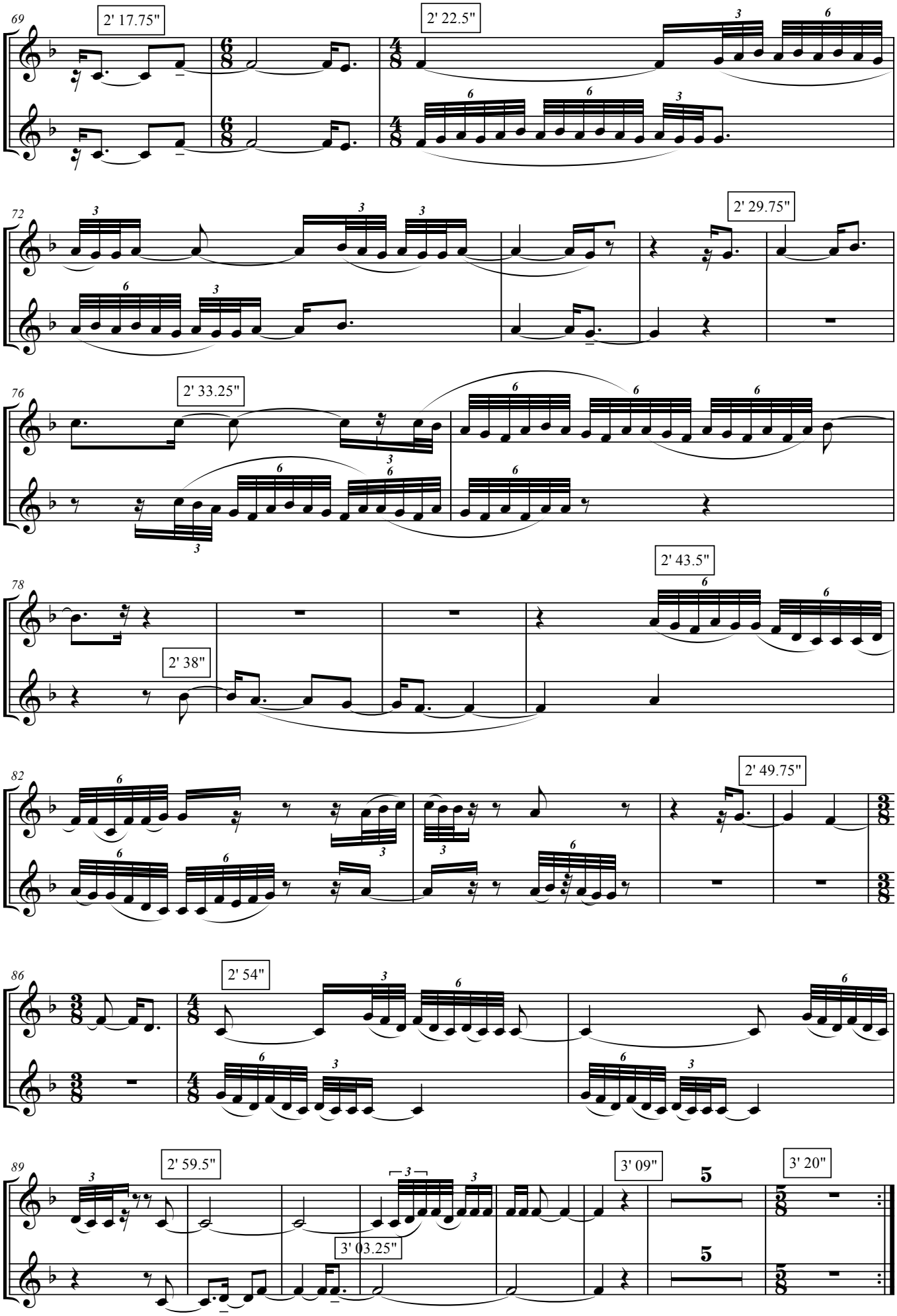
Dynamic inflections are not prescribed. The two flutists should use dynamics in order to imitate expressive singing. This can be unique to each performance. The different flute pairs can use different dynamics, but their overall levels should be balanced in such a way that no single voice is always clearer than the others.

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Canon 1: Streams (Score)



Canon 1: Streams (Score)



Canon 1: Streams (Score)

It is suggested that all flutists use this score (and not the parts) to learn the first statement of the compound melody and to practise in pairs to play the compound melody. This score presents only one statement of the compound melody and it contains indications of time-points called 'time-stamps'.

The two flutes should sound like one instrument when they perform the compound melody. Care should be taken that the dynamic levels and timbres blend completely so that the sounds of the instruments merge into one stream. The impression should be that of a single, rich singing voice. The flutists can use a more breathy tone than usual and the attacks can sometimes imitate the consonants of the singing voice. The short notes should be heard as a colouring of the main tone, and as one string, never as separate tones.

The rhythmic notation of all notes, except the thirty-second notes, are exact. Especially the starting points of each phrase should be precise, because sometimes a voice follows another in less than a second. If the rhythms are not performed exactly, the canon will be ruined.

When the interaction between the flutists is fluent, the different parts can be studied.

In order to ensure that the musicians stay together, this work should be practised and performed with one or more stopwatches that is/are visible to the musicians and invisible to the audience.

Each pair of flutists practise also from the part that will be used in performance. *Comes*-parts contain a 'summary' of the compound melody of their *duces*-pair in small print on the top staff. *Comes*-parts have no time-stamps, because *duces*-voices can enter at various time points depending upon

(a) which *duces*-pair they are following and (b) in which statement of the *duces*-pair they start.

A *comes*-pair can choose one of two points of entry and does not have to start at the same time-point in every performance. A *comes*-pair can also follow different *duces*-pairs in different performances. Once the point of entry for a specific performance is decided, the *comes*-pair should write into their part as many time-stamps as needed.

The work can be performed by any even number of flutists up to thirty-six flutes. It can be performed on any flute (C, alto, bass), but all flutists should use the same flutes. Some of the parts can be performed as recorded tracks. One or more flutists can improvise together with live performers, recorded tracks or both. The improviser(s) can use any flute, even if it is not the same flutes as in the ensemble or the recording, and the improviser(s) can change flutes during the improvisation.

Each pair of flutists can during a performance decide to remain silent for any number of beats. They should then enter correctly as if they were performing their part. In other words, remaining silent and not performing the whole part is possible, but re-entries should be at the prescribed moments. The pair can also together experiment with changing the timbres of their flutes.

The work can be performed in any suitable space, and the positions of listeners and performers are free and can be fluid. During performances, no visual material (other than the performers) should be presented. Presenting images of water during the performance is strongly discouraged. This is not background music, but music for reflection.

The work on this composition benefited from several performances and also from a residency in Morelia, Mexico in 2011 when I worked with Aleandro Escuer who also recorded earlier versions of the first two canons and gave performances of the canons as improviser. Performances in South Africa took place in Potchefstroom and in Stellenbosch, and two South African flutists, George Fazakas and Marietjie Pauw, played significant roles as performers and coordinators of the ensembles. *(March 2013)*

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